Epilogue: Iran to India

This volume has focused on an initially unknown and nomadic/transhumant clan among the inhabitants of the region of Ghur, in what is now central Afghanistan – their story beginning for our purposes in the early twelfth century. During the course of this same century, roughly by the 1150s CE, this group of Ghuri kinsmen emerged as a confederate empire of multiple lineages. They adopted the trappings of Perso-Islamic kingship (Chapter 1) and called themselves Shansabanis. By the 1170s CE, the three principal lineages of this confederacy were based at Jam-Firuzkuh, Bamiyan, and the latest at the erstwhile Yamini capital of Ghazna. The separate and at times contentious branches attained elite status and regional dominance throughout what is modern Afghanistan, and temporarily in eastern Iran and Turkmenistan. By the mid-1170s, the Ghazna Shansabanis in particular seized upon that region's geo-historical momentum to expand into the Indus-dependent valleys, and ultimately into the plains of the north Indian *duab* (Volume II).

This story of a meteoric rise from anonymity among central Afghanistan's nomad–urban continuum to the pinnacle of an empire encompassing a variety of cultural landscapes was not as unlikely as it might first appear. Indeed, by the twelfth century the Persianate world had experienced the influx of several waves of "outsider" groups, particularly from the eastern steppe lands of Turkic Eurasia. Chapter 1 traced how many of these newcomers had been able not only to establish even more expansive empires than the Shansabanis – the Saljuqs, for example – but also helped transform the Persianate *ecumene* into one that was *inclusive* of lifeways distinctly "other" to prior, conventional courtly models. The Persianate world's more aptly termed Perso-Islamic cultures of power mediated access to kingship within this world by means of Islamic confessionalism, patronage, and mobility. Rather than being exclusive and closed circuits of prestige, then, Perso-Islamic kingly cultures were in fact attainable for those groups and individuals with the perspicacity to decode them and the means to implement their acquired knowledge.

Chapter 2 attempted to piece together specifically the Shansabanis' beginnings among the nomads and other practitioners of transhumance in central Afghanistan – an effort that remains incomplete given the general